KRISTA RECKER PROPERTIES

THE MOVE-UP GUIDE

5 questions to ask before you sell and buy *at the same time.*

A short field guide for Greater Boston homeowners thinking about moving up. The questions inside are the ones that separate a smooth move from a stressful one, and a great move from an expensive one.

Strategy first. Decisions backed by data.

BEFORE YOU START

A move-up is two deals, *not one.*

The conversation usually starts simple. You love your home, you have outgrown it, and you are ready for the next one. Another bedroom, a yard, a shorter commute, a better school. The decision feels like one move and one upgrade, and the math, the timing, and the risk all run together as a single conversation about a single house.

A move-up is actually two transactions that have to dance with each other. A sale that has to net what you need it to net. A purchase that has to land at a payment you can actually live with. A timeline that has to either line up perfectly or get bridged on purpose. The clients who move up calmly are the ones who treat both sides as one strategy, not two errands. These are the five questions I walk every move-up client through before either side gets started.

How to use this guide

Read all five. Try the exercise at the end of each one. Bring the answers, or the questions you cannot answer, to whoever you trust to help you decide. Or bring them to me on a 30 minute strategy session. There is no commitment to list or buy.

01

QUESTION ONE · THE SEQUENCING

Are you selling first, buying first, *or trying to do both at the same time*?

WHY IT MATTERS

Most people pick the order by accident. They start looking at houses, fall for one, and the sequence gets decided by whichever side moved first. That is the most expensive way to choose. Selling first, buying first, and doing both simultaneously are three completely different strategies, with three different risk profiles and three different costs.

Selling first is the cleanest financially and the most stressful logistically. Buying first is the easiest logistically and the most exposed financially. Doing both at once is the smoothest experience and the hardest to coordinate. The right sequence depends on your equity position, your income, your storage options, your kids' school calendar, and what the Greater Boston market is rewarding in this exact window. Pick the sequence on purpose, before the first showing.

TRY THIS

Write down what would have to be true for each of the three sequences to work for your specific situation. The one with the shortest list of conditions is usually the right one.

02

QUESTION TWO · THE REAL EQUITY

How much equity will actually be available *to put toward the next house*?

WHY IT MATTERS

Most homeowners do the equity math from memory. They take what they think the home is worth, subtract what they think they owe, and call the rest their down payment. That number is almost never the real number. It is missing commissions, concessions, repairs, any holdover costs, the timing of when the proceeds actually become liquid, and what taxes look like if there is a gain above the exclusion.

Real equity is what hits the wire and clears in time to be used on the next house. The number that matters is not the list price. It is the net wire, accounting for the sale path, the timeline, and the gap between when proceeds land and when the next closing needs them. A move that pencils on an imaginary equity number can quietly fall apart at the real equity number once the math is honest.

TRY THIS

Have someone walk you through a net sheet on your current home, line by line, before you ever look at a new one. Then build the next purchase around that number, not the guess.

03

QUESTION THREE · THE NEW NUMBER

What does the new monthly actually look like *at today's rate and today's taxes*?

WHY IT MATTERS

Most move-up buyers are anchored to two numbers from their current home. The rate they locked years ago and the tax bill from an old assessment. A new home will not have either of those. Today's rate is a different number. The new town's tax rate is a different number. The new assessment will reset based on what you paid, not what the seller paid years ago. Insurance is a different number. Condo fees or HOA, if there are any, are a different number.

Run the full new monthly before you go look at houses, not after you find one. Principal, interest, taxes, insurance, any condo or HOA, and the utility differences for a bigger or older home. Then ask whether that number leaves your life intact. The mortgage you can technically qualify for and the mortgage that lets the rest of your life keep working are usually two different numbers.

TRY THIS

Add up the total new monthly at the price point you are considering. Live on that number for one month, set the difference aside, and see how it feels. Better to test it now than after closing.

04

QUESTION FOUR · THE BRIDGE

If the sale and the purchase do not line up perfectly, *how are you bridging the gap*?

WHY IT MATTERS

Almost no move-up goes perfectly on time. The sale closes a week before the purchase. The purchase closes three weeks before the sale. The buyer of your home pushes for an extra ten days. The seller of the new home cannot move out yet. Most move-up plans assume a clean handoff and then panic when the calendar disagrees.

Decide your bridge before you need one. A short rent back from the buyer of your current home. A short lease in between. A bridge loan. A HELOC tapped before listing. An offer written with a sale contingency. Family stays in town. Storage and a furnished rental. Each option has a cost, a risk, and a window where it is available. The right one gets decided on the strategy session, not at midnight three days before closing.

TRY THIS

Pick the bridge you would use if the gap was 30 days, 7 days, and 3 days. If you cannot answer all three, that gap is still unplanned risk.

05

QUESTION FIVE · THE STRESS TEST

What happens to the plan *if one side of this move* does not go the way you expect?

WHY IT MATTERS

Every move-up plan is built around an assumed outcome. The current home sells in four weeks at the expected price. The next house gets accepted on the first offer at the expected price. Financing approves on time. Inspections come back clean on both sides. When all of that happens, the move is easy. When even one piece slips, the plan that did not get stress tested starts costing money fast.

Walk the plan against three honest scenarios before you commit. Your home does not sell in the window you assumed. The new home you wanted goes under contract before you can offer. Financing on the new side gets repriced before closing. If the plan still works, even uncomfortably, you are buying a move. If it only works in the cleanest case, you are buying a hope. The calmest moves are the ones that already have a backup answer to the question that has not been asked yet.

TRY THIS

List the three things that would have to go wrong in this move to genuinely hurt. Write what you would do in each case. If you cannot, the plan needs another pass before either side starts.

READY WHEN YOU ARE

Want to map both sides with me *before you start?*

These are not the only questions worth running before a move-up. They are the ones I have watched separate the moves that feel smooth from the ones that get expensive fast. If you want to walk through them on your specific situation with me, that is what a strategy session is for. No commitment to list or buy.

Book my strategy session

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